

Concept first. Then controlled variation.

I build paid-social creative the way you would run an experiment: research the account, the competitors and the customer, write one clear hypothesis, turn it into a concept with more than one way in, brief it, launch it as one concept, and read the pattern before calling anything a winner. The same logic runs through statics, UGC scripts and long-form VSLs.

RESULTS, IN SHORT · SLOVENIAN DTC SKINCARE BRAND, TWO MONTHS, META ADS

21 → 15 € Face cream CPA. CVR 3% → 5,5%. Account ROAS 1,6 → 1,95.	18 → 11 € Deodorant CPA. CVR 6,5%, highest on the account.
27 → 17 € Scalp serum CPA. CTR doubled.	-30% Account CPA. Full funnel built for three products.

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WHAT I DO

I own the part of paid social that happens before the ad exists and after the numbers come in. Research, angle selection, personas, hooks, copy, briefs, production direction and the testing structure. Designers, editors and creators execute; I review against the idea and read the results.

Most of what you will see here I made myself: the research, the briefs, the copy and the visuals.

HOW I THINK ABOUT TESTING

I do not judge a whole concept from one ad. One weak hook can make a strong concept look bad, and one lucky hook can make an average execution look better than it is.

A target persona is not one person. It is a large group of people with different situations, different ways of thinking and different reactions. Betting that a single hook will land with all of them is a game of chance. So each concept becomes a small creative bank: the core angle and visual logic stay fixed, and only the way in changes. For a static that usually means one visual with several hook and copy variations. For a UGC video it means the same script filmed with different openings. For a VSL it means one story with several hook variants.

The concept is the unit I judge, not the individual ad. The ads inside it work together, and you never fully know which one did the job. The same person may see three of the eight ads in a concept and only react to the third, but the first two did their part. That is why I read spend, CTR, CPC, CVR and ROAS at the concept level. If several ways in perform, the angle has a real signal. If only one does, I keep learning before calling the concept a winner.

How many variations depends on the format and the budget. I start around five and go up or down from there. The point is not volume, it is enough controlled variation to tell whether performance comes from the angle, the execution or the copy, and to give Meta several executions of the same idea so different people in the same audience find the version that speaks to them.

Six small angles with no story above them give you "everything is fine" data and no winner. One main story, tested through variation, gives you something to scale.

The same six steps, every product

The format is never the strategy by itself. It is the vehicle for a specific message. Everything below exists so the next test is better than the last one.

01 Account research

What already works on the account, which formats performed, which never did, and where the spend actually sits.

EXAMPLE

On a skincare account one before/after ad from a year earlier was carrying 88% of the product's spend at a CPA of 21 €, frequency 3, and it was tired. Every format ever tested was product-forward. Nobody had tried a skeptic angle, an identity angle or a category-critique angle. That gap was the brief.

On the equestrian account, 15 video concepts turned out to be the same footage re-cut. Retention to 25% was 3 to 9%. The only two winners were short organic reels. The problem was not the product, it was the creative.

02 Competitor research

Meta Ad Library, market by market. What competitors run, and what has run long enough to be working for them. Not to copy, but to find the gap.

EXAMPLE

For the calming balm, every UK competitor sold powder or paste in the feed. Nobody sold a scent, one movement, one minute. Germany sold stress through physiology, so the German angle had to be measurable. The Netherlands had no competitor at all: an empty auction and the cheapest place to test.

For the face cream, the "needle versus cream" angle was saturated (one competitor alone had over 100 active ads on it), and creams with the same hero ingredient sat between 47 and 163 €. That gave us the price anchor and one angle to avoid.

03 Voice of customer

Forums, reviews and Reddit, read for the exact words people use about the problem, not the product. The hook comes from here. It is never invented.

EXAMPLE

Equestrian forums: "Calmers are a placebo effect on the owner." / "It's not a calmer, it just helps him deal with things better." / "I am an anxious rider and my gelding reads me like a book." Three quotes, three angles. The last one became the only angle nobody in the category had.

Skincare forums: women talking about creams they threw away, not believing ads, every cream after 40 looking the same. One of the winning hooks was almost verbatim: "How many creams have you already thrown away?"

Hypotheses, personas and the concept bank

Research becomes specific things worth testing, not a list of random formats. Eight to ten personas per product: half the ones everyone targets, half the ones nobody has touched yet. Then one main story above everything, and a bank of angles under it.

EXAMPLE

Calming balm: 8 personas, 40 angles, 120 hooks, 8 static formats and 6 video formats, mapped angle by angle. Three personas were white space. Test waves ordered by priority, and a note that reads: if only one wave ever gets made, these four angles.

Face cream: after the first wave the data looked "fine" everywhere and pulled nowhere. Six small angles, no roof. The fix was one sentence above all of them: skin after 40 does not lose moisture, it loses support. Everything already made fit under it, nothing was thrown away.

Briefs, copy and production

The brief is where the strategy either survives or dies. My rule is that whoever executes should be able to make the ad without asking me a single question, and should not be able to make a different ad by accident.

So one brief per concept, written with as much information as I can give: the persona, the one thought this concept has to land, a sketch of the layout, a description of how the finished ad should look and feel, the hook variations, the rules for this product, and the export names. I want the designer or the editor to see the whole picture, not just their piece of it. When they understand what the ad is for, they make better decisions in the places the brief cannot cover.

Every product gets a claim list before anything goes into production: what cannot be said and what to say instead. It is written from the regulation and the platform policy, and it is shared with the client and the creators. That way compliance is a design constraint at the start, not a rejection at the end.

Launch, read, iterate

One concept per campaign structure, judged at the concept level after a fixed spend or number of days, never on the first cheap or expensive impressions. Ads are not switched off by hand.

What I look at first: cost per outbound click, not CPC, because CPC counts taps on "more" that never leave the platform. Then the pattern: several ways in performing means a real angle; one lucky hook means keep learning; clicks but no conversions means message-to-offer or landing page; nothing after meaningful spend means next hypothesis.

EXAMPLE

On one account I found that 36% of paid clicks never left Meta, and that Facebook let 32 to 59% of clicks through while Instagram let 75 to 89%. Same creative, different placement. That was a media finding, not a creative one, and it changed what got fixed first.

The same UGC video ran at ROAS 2,06 from the creator's own profile and 0,38 from the brand's page. The earlier verdict that "UGC does not work" was a delivery mistake, not a content problem.

Every creative should either
produce performance or produce a
learning that makes the next test
better.

Face cream for skin over 40

CPA 21 € → 15 € Conversion rate 3% → 5,5% Account ROAS 1,6 → 1,95

Context

A face cream for women over 40, sold direct in Slovenia and Slovakia, Meta only. Price around 20 €, with a 3-pack offer and over 700 reviews at 4,7.

When I took over, one before/after ad from the previous year carried most of the product's spend at a CPA of 21 €, frequency 3, and it was fading. Everything ever tested on the account was product-forward. Nothing had been tested in a structured way.

The objective: a new static set that lowers CPA and keeps ROAS above break-even, and a system that keeps producing winners after that.

What I did

Researched the account history, the competitors in Ad Library and the customer voice on forums. Decided which formats to keep, which to add and which persona to test first. Wrote the hooks, the primary texts and the headlines. Briefed the designer, one brief per concept. Built the campaign structure. Reviewed with the owner and the media buyer, and iterated through three rounds before production.

Source insight

ACCOUNT	The before/after format had done its job. Nobody had tested a skeptic angle, an identity angle or a category-critique angle.
AD LIBRARY	The "needle versus cream" angle was saturated, one competitor alone had over 100 active ads on it. Creams with the same hero ingredient sat between 47 and 163 €, which gave us the price anchor.
FORUMS	Women talking about creams they threw away, about not believing ads anymore, about every cream after 40 looking the same. Three pain points: skepticism, promise versus price, and skin that changes after 40.
PURCHASE DATA	36 of 41 purchases were 45+. The persona was confirmed by the account, not assumed.

Concepts

Nine concepts across the funnel, each one visual with five text versions. Only the text changes between versions, so the hook is the isolated variable.

Top of funnel, three concepts:

GRID

The identity angle.

"Skin does not need more. It needs different."

HERO + QUESTION

The skeptic angle.

"How many creams have you already thrown away?"

TYPOGRAPHIC

The category angle.

"You are not paying for the story. You are paying for the cream."

Middle of funnel: a "what they promise, what you get" comparison against the category, an ingredient callout, and a "who this is for" card.

Bottom of funnel: cart reminders written for five different reasons people abandon, the 3-pack, and real reviews quoted verbatim.

From brief to live

The briefs went to production. When the visuals came back I checked each one against its brief: does it carry the one thought, does the layout match the sketch, are the rules respected. What needed fixing went back with notes, the rest went live.

Results and learning

CPA 21 € → 15 €. Conversion rate 3% → 5,5%. Account ROAS 1,6 → 1,95.

The winners were concepts, not single ads. That is the point of the method: I judge the concept as a whole, not which of its hooks happened to get the credit.

After testing the angles and the formats, I had a clear picture of what worked: the question-led concepts and the typographic manifesto. Once I found that solid base, I built on it, so the product had something stable I could keep working on and test new ideas against.

Face cream, selected statics

Each one is a single execution inside its concept. Brand names are blurred.



TOF Typographic manifesto



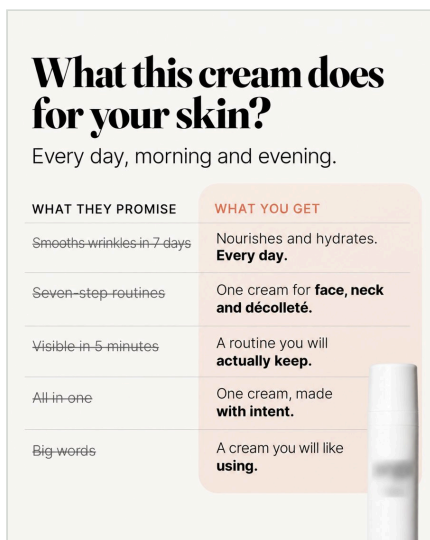
TOF Category critique



TOF Big promise



TOF Routine grid



MOF What they promise, what you get

Calming balm for horses

8 personas 40 angles 120 hooks 3 test waves 7-format mid-funnel library
3 UGC scripts

Context

A scent-based calming balm for horses and riders, a roll-on applied over the nostrils before a stressful situation: loading, the farrier, clipping, a new place. Sold direct across the UK, Germany and the Netherlands, with the home market used for content.

When I came in, the account had run the same generic copy across five countries for eight months. The videos were the same footage re-cut into fifteen "concepts", retention was 3 to 9%, and the only two ads that ever worked were short organic reels. The category itself is skeptical by default: the loudest customers on the forums believe no calmer works at all.

The objective: a creative strategy from the ground up, built for three very different markets, that the brand could keep producing from after I handed it over.

What I did

Research across four foundations: the evidence, the competition per market, the customer voice, and the rules. Eight personas, forty angles with an opening line each, ten scripting frameworks, fourteen formats. Then three top-of-funnel test waves, a seven-format mid-funnel library, bottom-of-funnel visuals, three UGC scripts and a voice specification written from the founder's own revisions.

Source insight

EVIDENCE

The only real study in the category measured heart rate variability in eight dressage horses inhaling lavender. Small sample, real measurement, published. That earned one careful phrasing and closed the door on everything else. No studies exist for the other two ingredients, so nothing was claimed for them.

COMPETITION

Every UK competitor sells powder or paste in the feed. Nobody sells a scent, one movement, one minute. Germany sells stress through physiology, so the German angle had to be measurable. The Netherlands had no competitor at all: an empty auction.

CUSTOMER VOICE

From the two largest equestrian forums: "Calmers are a placebo effect on the owner." / "It's not a calmer, it just helps him deal with things better." / "I am an anxious rider and my gelding reads me like a book." Six themes came out of it. The rider as half the problem was the only angle no competitor had.

RULES

The existing ads claimed fewer falls, fewer injuries and fewer vet visits. Those claims push a cosmetic product toward veterinary medicine under EU regulation, and they had to go. A forum thread also showed a ready buyer walking away because the ads used an AI-generated horse and the origin was hidden. Real horse, visible origin, became rule one.

Positioning

Not "the best natural calming aid". Instead: it does not sedate, it buys the horse five seconds to think before it reacts. Three pillars under that: five seconds not sedation, pre-diluted and safe instead of mixing oils in the tack room, and it works on both ends of the lead rope. Origin as proof.

Concepts

Top of funnel, three waves of five statics, each wave one hypothesis:

WAVE 1 · PROOF

Riders in this category buy from evidence, not atmosphere.
"Eight horses. One scent. Something changed in how they settled."

WAVE 2 · SITUATION

A recognisable moment stops the scroll better than proof does.
"He holds it together for forty minutes. Then he runs out."

WAVE 3 · SAFETY

The whole category never has to answer the safety question, this product does.
"Nothing goes into the horse."

One thought on the image, no product, no logo, no CTA. Real horse, natural light, nothing that looks like stock. UK and US text layers on every visual.

Middle of funnel, seven formats, three variants each, so the same argument can be tested in different shapes: us vs the category, features pointed out, problem to solution, text in context, benefit stack, listicle, education grid. Same off-white surface, same typography, real product on the same table in every one.

Bottom of funnel: price, offer and "introduced at home, used on the days that ask more". Real photography only, because the actual bottle cannot be generated.

UGC: three scripts, each a different format (customer story, research-led, demonstration), each with its own hook, so a failure tells you whether the problem is the format or the product.

Working with the founder

This project ran directly with the founder, not through an agency layer. I brought the research and the first two waves, she brought years of knowing that world from the inside: how her customers actually talk about their horses, what they will and will not believe, and where a line overstepped what anyone can promise about someone else's horse.

Her feedback gave me insights I could not have found on the internet. She corrected product facts, pointed out where a hook sounded like a supplement ad, and showed me the difference between a rider reading an ad and a rider trusting it. We went back and forth on the lines until we had versions we both stood behind.

That is how I prefer to work with a client: research first so the conversation starts from facts, then real back and forth, and a result that neither of us would have written alone.

What this shows

The creative on the next pages is the visible part. The part that made it possible is the research underneath it: the forum reading, the legal review, the market-by-market competitor map, and a bank of angles the brand can produce from for months without me.

Calming balm, mid-funnel formats

Seven formats, one message system. Each shown is a single execution inside its concept. Brand names are blurred.

**A powder in the feed.
Or a scent on the nose.**

FED DAILY	USED WHEN NEEDED
× Loading week before it works	✓ Apply on the day
× Given every day	✓ Only for the moments that need it
× Must be eaten	✓ Nothing goes into the horse
× Hope he finishes the bucket	✓ You see it applied



F1 Us vs Them

**Six things in the tube.
Six things on the label.**



Scent only. Nothing goes into the horse.

F2 Features Point Out

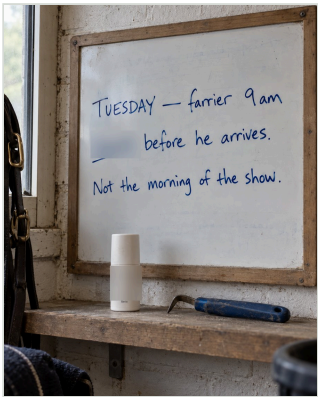
**The farrier.
The clippers.
The first cold morning.**

-  A stranger holding his foot
-  A noise he cannot place
-  A ramp that moves under him
-  The first sharp morning of autumn

A better starting point.



F3 Problem to Solution



F4 Text in Context



Nothing daily.

-  Nothing goes into his feed
-  Already diluted, ready to use
-  Works through scent, not sedation
-  About one to three hours, reapply when needed

— 50 ml - 24.99 EUR

F5 Benefit Stack

**Four things to watch for
after you roll it on.**

- 01 **Chewing**
- 02 **Licking**
- 03 **A yawn**
- 04 **The lower lip going soft**

He will tell you. You just have to be looking.



F6 Listicle

Six moments that ask more of him.

-  The trailer
-  The farrier
-  The clippers
-  First cold morning
-  A new arena
-  Box rest

— a calming balm for horses that works through scent.

F7 Education Grid

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